[FACILITATION TOOLS]

OPEN COACHING

Open coaching is not problem solving. It gets the presenter below the facts to the core struggle, then hands the room a prompt for experience shares. About 5 minutes for an impromptu, 7 to 8 for a deep dive.

ASK THESE FOUR QUESTIONS [one at a time, then let them talk for 2–3 minutes]

1. **The headline.** "What is a single-sentence headline for this topic?" One sentence. If they give you two, ask for one.
2. **The feelings.** "What are three emotions you feel about it?"
3. **Where they want to land.** "One year from now, what would you love to be able to say about this?" Where they are and where they want to be is the tension. How they get there is not the coach's job.
4. **What they are curious about.** "What types of experiences are you curious to hear from the group?" Curious to hear, not what they want the group to tell them.

THEN ASK QUESTIONS TO FIND THE CORE TOPIC [questions only: no advice, no consoling]

1. **Go below the surface.** "Why is that important to you?" "Why is that significant?" "What do you realize about yourself?"
2. **Split the topic.** When you hear two topics, name both and ask which one is more alive. The other one goes on the parking lot.

> *"Is this more about doubting yourself as a leader, or about whether you are still following your passion or your obligation?"*
> *"Is this more about a temporary burnout, or a permanent loss of passion for your business?"*
> *"You talked about tension in your family, and about hating to confront people. Which one is bubbling up for you more?"*
>
> SPLITTING QUESTIONS, FROM COLTON'S COACHING

CLOSE: DEFINE THE PROMPT [no round of clarifying questions]

1. **Know when you are there.** "I guess what I'm really struggling with is..." means you found it. Stop asking. "Have you tried..." and "What if you..." are problem solving, not coaching.
2. **Read back what you heard.** "I heard you say you felt betrayed by someone you trusted."
3. **Give the prompt.** "Think of a time when you were losing passion for something that felt safe, and you were ready for something else."
4. **Silence, then shares.** After 60 seconds of quiet, each member shares what resonated with them or bubbled up while listening to the coaching, or follows the prompt. Steeped in the feelings it stirred, not the details of the situation.

Sources: Created by Colton Mulligan for Forum Playbook. v4.0 (Nov 2026) rebuilds the sheet around the four questions Colton opens every coaching with, from his 2026 moderator trainings. IQ topics skip open coaching; see EQ vs IQ Topics: Sizing the Conversation.